

As Royal Challengers Bengaluru secured its second successive IPL title, there was jubilation, certainly. But there was also validation.

A year ago, RCB had finally ended nearly two decades of waiting. The celebrations were then fuelled by relief; the burden of history had finally been lifted.

This triumph felt different.

This was not about ending a drought. It was about proving the first title was no accident. Defending a championship is often tougher than winning one. Expectations rise. Opponents spend months dissecting your strengths. Every defeat is scrutinised more closely.

Success often creates its own anxieties. The temptation is to search for improvements everywhere, even when little is broken.

RCB chose a different path.

Under head coach Andy Flower, batting coach and mentor Dinesh Karthik and director of cricket, Mo Bobat, continuity became a strength. The core remained intact, but the franchise quietly addressed areas that needed strengthening. There was trust in a group that had already shown what it was capable of.

That approach shone throughout the season. Players retained their roles after poor outings, and selections were not dictated by

short-term results. Even during occasional setbacks, there was little sign of panic.

RCB opened its campaign by brushing aside Sunrisers Hyderabad at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium and rarely loosened its hold on the tournament thereafter.

By the halfway mark, RCB looked more certain of its identity than any other side in the competition.

"Last year was a lot of pressure. This year was calmer because of the way we played throughout the tournament," Patidar admitted after the final. "We didn't just play well, we dominated." One week, it was Kohli anchoring the innings. On another,



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